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Assignment Feedback Sheet

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Module Title:	Dissertation
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Assignment Title:	How are the Tensions Between Desire and Disillusionment Presented for Women in Nineteenth and Twentieth Century American Fiction?

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Assessment Matrix

	Class 1		2:1	2:2	3	Fail		
	(100-85)	(84 - 70)	(69-60)	(59-50)	(49-40)	(39-20)	(19-1)	(0)
Knowledge and understanding								
Close reading and analysis								
Evaluation								
Research, enquiry, secondary sources								
Quality of argument								
Presentation & referencing								
Communication								

How are the Tensions Between Desire and Disillusionment Presented for Women in Nineteenth and Twentieth Century American Fiction?

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Contents

Introduction 1

“I wish I could fix things for you as I do my heroines!": Women’s Writing, Work and Wealth in *Little Women* 3

“But my freedom – is that nothing?”: Scandal, Scrutiny and Status in *The Age of Innocence* 9

“Janie’s first dream was dead, so became a woman”: Sexuality, Selfhood and Survival in *Their Eyes Were Watching God* 13

Conclusion 20

Works Cited 24

How are the Tensions Between Desire and Disillusionment Presented for Women in Nineteenth and Twentieth Century American Fiction?

Introduction

In this dissertation, I analyse how the female protagonists in Louisa May Alcott's *Little Women*, Edith Wharton's *The Age of Innocence* and Zora Neale Hurston's *Their Eyes Were Watching God* grapple with desire, disillusionment and the tensions between them. As these texts are written by American women, they provide an authentic and nuanced insight into the female experience of nineteenth, and early-twentieth century American society which they infuse into their female protagonists. These novels 'express the same concerns as feminist theory: the unique experience of women in history; the notion of female consciousness; the definitions of gender that limit and oppress; and the cause of women's liberation from those restrictions' (Madsen ix) through the presentation of the lives of Josephine March, Countess Ellen Olenska and Janie Mae Crawford. Both Alcott, Wharton and Hurston go beyond presenting the desires of their protagonists as merely unconventional and instead delve into what that makes their desires ostensibly impossible to achieve by presenting the limitations of the American society that they exist within rather than their ambitions. I will argue how Jo, Ellen and Janie become disillusioned in the pursuit of their desires by their inabilities to transcend the social, economic and legal limitations placed upon them because of their sex. I will also compartmentalise the oppression they face as they strive for towards their ambitions by examining the female experience of desire and disillusionment in these nineteenth-century texts under an intersectional feminist lens.

I use the term intersectional Feminism as an analytical framework derived from the theory of intersectionality, which is a term first coined by Kimberlé Crenshaw in the context of law 'to expose the different types of discrimination and disadvantages that are imposed upon people as a consequence of a unique combination of various identities' (Gerdtz 2), specifically upon black women. However, in my research, I use the concept of intersectionality more broadly across the lives of three different women with varied intersectional identities, to determine how the relationship between desire and disillusionment is intertwined with the disadvantages of their individual intersectional

identities. This allows me to demonstrate how Jo, Ellen and Janie are all marginalised within different eras of American society, regardless of which unique combination of identities they possess. In each chapter, I compartmentalise each female protagonists' intersectional identity to discuss their individual desires and interrogate how the socio-economic landscape of each American society uses their intersectional identities against them to prevent them from being fulfilled. In Chapter One, I examine the effect of the overlapping intersections of identity of sex, gender and lower-class upon Jo's desires to become a successful writer and financially provide for her family. Then, in Chapter Two, I investigate the culmination of oppression that Ellen faces for the combination of her upper-class and female identities in her pursuit of her desire to divorce and live free of scandal and scrutiny. And finally, in Chapter Three, I analyse the impact of the trisection of Janie's race, sex and lower-class identities upon her desires to embody her sexuality, assert her selfhood and personal agency.

Furthermore, by approaching the texts in order of publication, I map the female protagonists' experiences of the tensions between desire and disillusionment against the emerging Feminist ideologies of first and second-wave Feminism in late-nineteenth and early twentieth-century America. I begin with *Little Women,* which is set in the 1860s Massachusetts amid first-wave Feminism, which aligns Jo's internal conflict between desire and disillusionment with the emergence of women's suffrage in America. During '1860, the national census reported that only 15% of all free women were engaged in paid labor, and most were single or widowed' (Siegel 1084), which Alcott emphasises in her novel through Jo's struggle to work and infiltrate the public sphere. Alcott distills the values of first wave feminists for equal prospects for work for men and women into Jo's pursuit of her desire to become a writer, as Alcott constructs the publishing offices as masculine spaces. Jo attempts to transcend the nineteenth-century notion that 'income-producing work as often as not was located in the household' (Siegel 1086), through her persistent refusal of the limited domestic opportunities for work that society offers her as she continues to publish her writing.

Next, I examine *The Age of Innocence,* which is set in the 1920s during the murmurings of second-wave Feminism before it became a fully-fledged movement in the 1960s. Despite the era that Wharton wrote *The Age of Innocence*, Ellen's experiences of the tensions

between desire and disillusionment can be recognised as reminiscent of the feelings of injustice that sparked second-wave Feminism. Specifically, the injustice of being under constant observation as a woman to follow strict entrenched societal norms that constitute one's class and sex. This allows me to highlight the complex female experience of America's changing socio-economic climate, which harbored engrained values of patriarchal American society pre-first wave Feminism but promised that opportunities had changed for women.

Then, finally, I look at *Their Eyes Were Watching God* which is set in early-twentieth America between 1900s and the 1930s as the origins of second-wave Feminism was gaining more momentum. However, for women like Janie, second-wave Feminism was largely exclusive to the rights of middle-to-upper class white women, which disregarded the fight for same rights for women of colour and women from different ethnic backgrounds. For many, second-wave Feminism was a 'deemphasized or ignored a class and race analysis, generally seeing equality with men as the goal of feminism and has an individual rights-based, rather than justice-based vision for social change' (Thompson 337) which discouraged women like Janie from following their desires. In my research, I pinpoint that Janie's experience of the tensions between her desires and disillusionment stems from the marginalisation of lower-class black women for their sex, race and class identities from second-wave Feminism.

I demonstrate how each author presents the female protagonists' disillusionment at their ability to achieve their ambitions as rooted in the friction between the illustrious possibilities that new-wave Feminism presented and the entrenched heteronormative and exclusive conservative values of nineteenth-century America. Ultimately, I emphasise that the common intersection of sex that Jo, Ellen and Janie's share impacts and reshapes their desires the most which subjugates them into disillusionment.

"I wish I could fix things for you as I do my heroines!": Women's Writing, Work and Wealth in *Little Women*

Louisa May Alcott's 1869 novel *Little Women* follows the lives of the March family from childhood to adulthood amid socio-economic struggles after falling into poverty during the American Civil War. The matriarchal family, comprised of sisters Jo, Amy, Beth and Meg and

mother Marmee, each possess varied and nuanced desires for what they wish their life to be and who they want to become. Alcott exhibits how the civil war results in a mass 'status dissonance—an episode created from equal parts of class desire and a sense of class injury' (Foote 71) through the ambitious desires of the March girls. The sisters begin to recognise the futility of hierarchy as they are exposed to the effects of war and consequently choose to pursue their individual dreams despite the lingering notions of the status quo. In this chapter, I examine how Alcott relates Jo's experience of status dissonance to the possibility of fulfilling her desires as it 'centres upon how others perceive the ambitions and limitations of the March family' (Foote 71) after their decline in socio-economic status.

Specifically, I investigate how the female and lower-class intersections of Jo's identity heighten the tensions between her desire to financially support her family and pursuing her lifelong ambition to become a writer. As Judith Fetterley asserts, 'equal to the concern in *Little Women* for defining the proper ideal womanly character is the concern for defining woman's proper sphere and proper work' (Fetterley 372), which revolves Jo's struggles around her attempt to move from the feminine domestic sphere to the masculine public sphere. I will highlight how Jo becomes disillusioned by the condemnation that her sex, gender and class have upon her attempts to transcend the domestic sphere and to break into the writing and publishing field, but they do not stop her from doing so.

Alcott depicts Jo's desire to write and become a celebrated author as her primary passion which she attempts to pursue throughout her life. For Jo, the physical act of writing is an all-encompassing 'vortex' (Alcott 308) in which she 'writes away with all her heart and soul' (308) in a cathartic frenzied expression of her mind. The disorientating imagery of a 'vortex' (308) illustrates the vast multitude of ideas floating around in Jo's mind, as if chaotically bouncing off each other with her pen unable to keep up. Further, until her writing is 'finished she can find no peace' (Alcott 308), which borrows language from spirituality to suggest that symbolically Jo's soul is intrinsically bound to her work. This emphasises that Jo's desire to write is an inherent passion thus her need to complete her writing, so it is portrayed exactly as she envisions, is insatiable. Thus, when Amy burns her manuscript, this is a violent decimation of the established sacred spiritual relationship between Jo and her writing. Jo is understandably drastically disillusioned by such cruelty, because Amy irreversibly destroys every literary idea, story or concept Jo has ever written or conceived.

Although 'Jo's mother and sisters understand the significance of "Amy's bonfire," [...] they cannot quite understand the intensity of Jo's response' (Foote 68), but I justify her response as rightly multifaceted, enraged at Amy's deliberate destruction of her personal creation and the chances of fulfilling her dreams of publishing it. Jo's disillusioned response is also one of injustice, as her manuscript was sole controlled and made by her because writing is the only thing in her life, she has full autonomy over and Amy symbolically usurps her in its destruction.

However, Jo's desire to become a writer becomes reignited and finally actualised when she manages to sell her first sensationalist story. Finally, 'fortune suddenly smiles upon Jo, and drops a good-luck penny in her path' (Alcott 308), which personifies fortune as an empathetic figure that rewards Jo's manic efforts to have her writing noticed. The personified fortune recognises the economic value of Jo's writing and hails Jo as a working member of society, which demonstrates that Jo has finally managed to emancipate herself from the domestic sphere and infiltrate the public one. However, Alcott does imply that Jo's work has limited monetary value, connoted by the coin's distinctive 'not golden' (308) lack of lustre and quantitively low monetary value. Regardless, Jo continues 'writing sensation stories – for those dark ages, even all-perfect America read rubbish' (Alcott 399) to capitalise upon the moment when her work has been noticed. Jo acknowledges that writing within the sensationalist genre operates within the patriarchal parameters of successful nineteenth-century women's writing so she manipulates it to her advantage. These boundaries restricted women to write fiction which 'dealt with crime, often murder as an outcome of adultery and sometimes of bigamy, in apparently proper, bourgeois, domestic settings' (Brantlinger 1), but most of all aim to use emotive language to 'tantalize the reader' (Brantlinger 1) with shocking promiscuity.

This causes the process of writing to consequently become exhaustive for Jo, as she sacrifices the joy and creativity of writing to maximise the volume of her literary output to meet deadlines and meet the strict requirements of the sensationalist genre. Her state of writing as a 'vortex' (Alcott 309) begins to assume darker, more compulsive connotations, as she begins to neglect her health for literary productivity, becoming 'hungry, sleepy, cross and despondent' (Alcott 309) in ardent pursuit of gaining socio-economic capital. Although writing sensationalist fiction momentarily reclaims the oppressive boundaries upon the

female intersection of her identity in the writing space, it diminishes Jo's desire to write. Her literary work degrades 'from burning genius to a state where what she writes isn't even hers' (Fetterley 374), devoid of imagination and possibility because she is devoid of a space to express it.

Thus, Jo moves to New York in hopes to find a place and accepting space to publish and share her own authentic and creative writing, however she is only further disillusioned by the discovery that writing and publishing in 1860s America is a male-dominated field that she will never be able to penetrate. Alcott distinctly constructs the publishing offices of New York as a masculine space which emphasises the lack of female representation in nineteenth century publication houses:

'She had a womanly instinct that clothes possess an influence more powerful over many than the worth of her character or manners. So she dressed herself in her best, and, trying to persuade herself that she was neither excited nor nervous, bravely climbed two pairs of dark and dirty stairs to find herself in a disorderly room, a cloud of cigar smoke, and the presence of three gentlemen sitting with their heels rather higher than their hats, which articles of dress none of them took to remove on her appearance. Somewhat daunted by this reception, Jo hesitated on the threshold, murmuring in much embarrassment' (Alcott 400)

Immediately upon entering the space, Jo is overly conscious of her female appearance as she predicts that that her female body will be highly scrutinised, just as her work will be. Alcott exhibits that Jo discerns that the appearance, thus gender, of the writer will 'possess an influence more powerful over many than the worth of [...] character or manners' (400) upon the success of the meeting and consequent prospects of publication. This constructs a gender binary within the space in which she is the 'other' which she must 'bravely' (400) traverse to enter and symbolically enter the publishing industry. Further, the office is shrouded in a great 'cloud of cigar smoke' (400), which indicates the dominant presence of cigars in the space and symbolises the dominant presence of the phallocentric which also pollutes the space. Cigars were more expensive than cigarettes, which also portrays smoking them as a performative act of symbolic economic power.

In addition, Jo's hesitant ascension of the 'dark and dirty stairs' (400) suggests she suspects that she and her writing will be degraded upon entering the office and more widely the publishing field. Alcott exhibits that Jo is already conscious that she must use her 'womanly instinct' (400) to survive in such an alien masculine space. Further, the 'three gentlemen sit with their heels [...] higher than their hats' (400), which demonstrates their egotistical perceptions of themselves and their writing by disrespecting professional conduct. This is reinforced by how they do not take off their hats 'on her appearance' (400) which blatantly disrespects Jo by not hailing her as worthy of speaking to her politely or professionally. Alcott encapsulates the 'disorderly room' (400) to be physically and emotionally disorientating for Jo as an explicitly male-dominated space which both intimidates and disillusions her about her ability to break into the literary industry.

Furthermore, it is essential to consider that inherent to Jo's literary aspirations is her desire to financially support herself and her family in the absence of her father. This disrupts 'the hierarchical division of labour within the family which assigned the husband the role of breadwinner and the wife the role of domestic manager and moral guardian that emerged [...] in the nineteenth century' (Scott 41) because Jo desires to assume the role at the head of the family. By extension, Jo desire to nurture and provide for her family with the money she would earn from selling her writing embodies both maternity and paternity. Notably, 'for much of Alcott's childhood and youth, her family was financially dependent on whatever Mrs. Alcott and her daughters were able to earn outside the home' (Dawson 112), which infuses understanding of the lower-class female struggle for economic capital in a untraditional family structure and the necessity of disrupting the patriarchal structure of family for survival into Jo's characterisation.

Jo recognises that America is constituted by an entrenched socio-economic structure in which 'men have to work and women marry for money' (Alcott 182) and declares 'Oh don't I wish I could fix things for you as I do my heroines!' (Alcott 182). Alcott exhibits that Jo acknowledges that America is a place in which she does not have authority over her own life like she does over her literary narratives, because women possess no autonomy in the public sphere and rely upon marriage for money. However, Jo does not accept this path that the 'dreadfully unjust world' (Alcott 182) has predestined for women for herself or her sisters and relentlessly tries numerous ways to make money outside of the domestic sphere.

For example, Jo sells her hair to pay for Marmee to visit their father in hospital once he returns home from the war unexpectedly injured:

'I only sold what was mine [...] I hadn't the least idea of selling my hair at first, but as I went along, I hadn't the least idea of *what* I could do, and feeling as if I'd like to dive into some of the rich stores and help myself [...] in a barber's window I saw tails of hair with the prices marked' (Alcott 187-188)

Upon first appearance this is as an empowering feminist act in which Jo exploits the patriarchal feminine symbolic value of her hair which constitutes part of her erotic capital, her only tradable capital on the marriage market, for material gain. Jo is proud that she has 'earned it' (187), excitedly declaring to her mother and sisters 'it's mine honestly' (187), overjoyed that the money she obtained will make a tangible difference to her mother's life by providing her with the opportunity to see their father potentially one last time. However, upon closer inspection, this is a limited act of Feminism in which Jo turns to selling parts of her body as a commodity to accrue economic capital. The italicisation of *'what'* (188) emphasises that Jo possesses nothing else deemed valuable to the marketplace of the public sphere, so she has no choice but to sell something that is valuable in the domestic sphere – something of beauty. Therefore, she uses the values of the patriarchy to her advantage to make the most of her limited opportunities to earn money.

Furthermore, Jo's economic ambitions are primarily motivated by the stereotypically maternal and feminine desire to better the lives of her family, which I argue is the only reason that her character possesses the desire for wealth. In nineteenth-century America, 'waged work came to mean work outside of the home and thus engagement with the public sphere of commerce' (Dawson 114), so I perceive that 'Alcott's working heroines [...] had to find ways to reconcile the domestic sphere with the public one' (114) in order to participate in it. Hence, Alcott characterises Jo with the desire to fulfil the dreams of the family by restoring their once-loved home comforts and home environment which justifies Jo connecting her domestic sphere with the public one.

"But my freedom – is that nothing?": Scandal, Scrutiny and Status in *The Age of Innocence*

Edith Wharton's 1920 novel *The Age of Innocence* paints the strictly divided and socially regulated landscape of 1870s New York, from the perspective of prominent socialite and model upper-class gentleman Newland Archer. Consequently, this has led critics to narrow their analytical focus onto Newland's experiences of desire and disillusionment, which boil down to a struggle between his personal desire and duty in pursuit of maintaining his reputation. This has reduced the presence of the female characters in the text to mere one-dimensional signifiers of Newland's desires, representing either personal desire or duty, rather than possessing desires and struggles of their own. Problematically, 'readers are given Newland's perceptions of May and Ellen, not as who they actually are but as his desire situates them' (Sevinc 6), which inaccurately projects inauthentic personalities and fantasies onto the female characters to serve his visions of them and their significance to himself. This is mirrored by the structure of the novel, which does not portray Ellen herself until as late as Chapter Seven, by which point the representations of her have been constructed by the preconceptions and ideas of the other socially respected characters in the novel.

Therefore, in this chapter, I aim to broaden the scope of analysis and discourse of desire in the text by spotlighting the desires of the infamous Countess Ellen Olenska and how she grapples with becoming disillusioned by her ability to achieve them in 1870s American society. I argue that it has been easy for critics to dismiss Ellen's desires as she is characterised with such naivety with regards to scandal, reputation and American customs. However, I argue that her experience of the tensions between desire and disillusionment illuminates a more nuanced insight into the rigidity of 1870 American society and how it impacts selfhood rather than reputation or ego. As *The Age of Innocence* is *s*et on the cusp of the nineteenth century, I will argue how Ellen's pursuit of her desires can be recognised as one of the 'new personality types and new forms of behaviour [...] appearing among American women and [...] the ways in which talented and ambitious women first began to break through those constraints' (Scott 679). Specifically, I will examine how Ellen grapples with her desire to divorce, her desire for Newland and her desire to detach from her European identity for survival and how they result in her alienation from society.

Initially, Ellen moves to America to fulfil her desire to divorce her husband but becomes rapidly disillusioned as she realises that 1870 America is not the illustrious space of possibility for freedom and acceptance, she hopes that it is. Newland acts as a mouthpiece for wider society when he advises Ellen on the damning reality of what pursuing divorce in America entails, explaining that the 'legislation favours divorce-our social customs don't' (Wharton 107), which paints the paradoxical socio-political dynamic Ellen will find herself embroiled within. Wharton demonstrates the isolating liminal space that American women who desire divorce find themselves within, simultaneously reprimanded for being within a clearly unhappy marriage and equally chastised for attempting to pursue escape via divorce. This also emphasises the finality of scandal in 1870s American society by suggesting that the defiance of social customs is as bad, if not worse than defying the law.

Ellen persists past the inevitable outcome of becoming irreversibly scandalised in ardent pursuit of her freedom, she insists 'my freedom – is that nothing?' (Wharton 108), amplifying her defiance that she should sacrifice something as fundamental as her liberty for the sake of preserving her reputation. By extension, she also refuses to protect that of her husband, which 'breaks the rule that a wife's place was at her husband's side when he was in trouble by leaving'(Singley 516) as she believes that she should not be shamed for her husband's cruelty. This resistance embodies the qualities of the New Woman who were later recognised in the nineteenth century as women who were 'shut out by social convention from [...] participation, in major social structures, that began to build organisations and institutions that they themselves could control' (Scott 679), through how Ellen exercises her legal right to divorce for freedom and capital, participating in American laws. However, it is the tension between the allusion of power that Ellen possesses in her legal right to attempt to pursue a divorce and Newland's lack of faith in her desire that leaves Ellen ultimately disillusioned. Wharton paints that 'the fire had crumbled down to greyness' (Wharton 109) which symbolises how Ellen's burning passion for freedom from divorce has been extinguished by Newland's recounting of the harsh reality that she lives in.

Simultaneously, Ellen both embodies and exercises desire in her pursuit of Newland. Wharton codes Ellen with erotic capital which 'combines beauty, sex appeal, liveliness [...] charm [...] and sexual competence' (Hakim 8) in her appearance and behaviour to demonstrate how her desirable nature is both tempting and intimidating. Immediately,

Newland is struck by Ellen's 'mysterious authority of beauty' (Wharton 67-68) which is communicated effortlessly through her body language in 'in the carriage of the head' (67-68) and 'the movement of the eyes' (67-68) which effervesces her natural confidence. Wharton depicts how her self-conscious erotic capital is 'in the least theatrical' (67-68), which presents Ellen's beauty and confidence as refreshingly authentic and thus rare in a society of superficial beauty and practiced poise. The sexual allure of Ellen's beauty is derived from how she looks at Newland seeming 'highly trained' (67-68), as if she has captivated men with her eyes before, suggesting that Ellen is experienced in the art of seduction. This heightens the power of her erotic capital over Newland as this paints her as 'a countess doubtlessly experienced in courtly customs' (Daigrepont 2), which cements her as more sexually dominant and experienced than Newland and foreshadows how she will 'play a complicit and even at times a leading part' (2) in their affair.

Furthermore, Wharton presents Ellen's active pursuit of Newland as decidedly not feminine, independently 'walking alone across the wide drawing-room to sit down at Newland Archer's side' (Wharton 69). This defies the unspoken social 'etiquette required that she should wait [...] while the men who wished to converse with her succeeded each other at her side' (69), instead overtly leaving the company of one man for another that she desires more. This flippant movement between men mirrors her implied casual movements between male lovers, which reinforces the controversial nature of her sexual experiences and her public behaviour. However, Newland admires Ellen's masculine behaviour as 'sex appeal can also be about personality, [...] masculinity, a way of being in the world, characteristic of social interaction' (Hakim 9) and for its rarity in late nineteenth-century American society. Wharton depicts Ellen to drastically oppose the 1870 social etiquette for bourgeois women, which portrays her behaviour as masculine by contrast, in a reversal of heteronormative desire in which she pursues her desire for a man instead of waiting for him to pursue her. Despite Ellen's 'beauty - a gift which, in the eyes of New York, justified every success, and excused a certain number of failings' (Wharton 30-31) in a world where 'sex appeal is in short supply and [...] therefore universally valued' (Hakim 9), Ellen becomes isolated in a liminal space of desiring and being desirable without the freedom to express it nor indulge in it without being socially policed. It is this dynamic that leads Ellen to become disillusioned, as she discovers the impossibility of achieving her desire of being with

Newland as she comes to understand the futility of her erotic capital because she is unable to use it under 1870 social dictation. Although Newland recognises her erotic capital 1870 American society will never will.

Ellen becomes further disillusioned as she realises that all of 1870 America, not just the bourgeois society she exists within, is a space that fundamentally inhibits 'two human beings who love each other, who are the whole life to each other' (Wharton 246) be together because of its relentless entrenched obsession with class and the past. Ellen is infuriated that Newland suggests that her only option to actualise her desire, as she is unable to trade her erotic capital, would be 'to 'live with him as his mistress – since she can't be his wife (246). Ellen is insulted by Newland's romantic naivety that living as his mistress should and would be enough for her to be fulfilled and satisfied and further offended by his belief that their unique situation would be granted permission to be excused from the social segregation and surveillance weaved into the very fabric of their society. Ellen recognises that even if she managed to get a divorce and then pursue Newland, their relationship would still not be accepted because of his previous public engagement to May.

Ellen also desires to detach herself from her European identity to more seamlessly assimilate into bourgeois New York. Throughout the novel Wharton consistently codes Ellen with European features and customs, with the most notable being her fashion, which subjects her to ridicule, villainisation and isolation. As Wharton herself 'recognized from an early age the importance of a meticulously composed female appearance and its intrinsic power' (Evans 361), it is vital to look at the deliberate fashion choices she makes for Ellen as 'a moral code that can be read into her clothing' (361). At the beginning of the novel, in the theatre, Ellen's fashion is a spectacle which is intensely scrutinised by society because it is her first public appearance since returning from Europe and the scandalised breakdown of her marriage. Here, Ellen adorns a 'dark blue velvet gown rather theatrically caught up under her bosom by a girdle with a large old-fashioned clasp' (Wharton 28), which appalls society for its European non-conformity to the current styles of New York and its overtly sexually provocative nature. Instead of passive modesty, her European gown is 'theatrically caught up under her bosom' (Wharton 28) which unapologetically accentuates and displays Ellen's natural sexuality. Wharton's choice of a girdle over a corset aligns Ellen with the

defiance and agency of the New Woman as she refuses to wear clothing that confines and restricts her, instead opting for undergarments that provide comfort as well as style. In a society where 'corsets were respectable, and an uncorseted female figure was usually perceived as morally corrupt' (Evans 365-366), Wharton demonstrates how Ellen is perceived as a perversion of the ideal American woman as she refuses to wear an item of clothing that is designed to make her into a mere 'commodity on the marriage mart' (365-366). Wharton manipulates Ellen's European fashion to 'associate Ellen [...] as the "other" for Old New York [...] as a threat to society' (Sevinc 10), which alienates her in a liminal space of being paradoxically fascinating and detestable and denied entry to American society.

This propels Ellen into the realms of disillusionment as she comes to understand that she cannot just 'wipe out her past' (Wharton 106) and become an American again, because American society will always view her as the feared foreign other. Although she longs to become 'a complete American again, like the Mingotts and the Wellands' (Wharton 71), I perceive that it is their renowned cultural capital and the respect and freedom that grants them in America that she really desires - not the label of American identity. Wharton presents Ellen to have witnessed the ferocious socio-economic landscape of 1870 America and actively decided to leave it, in recognition that she will never achieve her desires of freedom, individuality and love because the parameters in which women must exist are minuscule. Ultimately, *The Age of Innocence* exhibits through Ellen's character that in late nineteenth century America, 'a woman can reveal her own subjectivity, Wharton suggests, only at the cost of exclusion from the symbolic system' (Davis 7), which is epitomised at the end of the novel when Ellen returns to Europe to finally satisfy her desires.

"Janie's first dream was dead, so became a woman": Sexuality, Selfhood and Survival in *Their Eyes Were Watching God*

In *Their Eyes Were Watching God*, Zora Neale Hurston spotlights the black female experience of the tensions between desire and disillusionment in early twentieth-century America through the life of the protagonist Janie Mae Crawford. Janie chases a life of love,

freedom and independence across 1930's Eatonville after the death of her grandmother and leaving an abusive marriage. Throughout the narrative of Janie's life, Hurston represents how her 'intersectional identity as both women *and* of color within discourses that are shaped to respond to one or the other, women of color are marginalized within both' (Crenshaw 1243- 1244) as she attempts to achieve her desires. The novel maps the development of Janie's desires from girlhood to womanhood against her growing awareness of the black and female intersections of her identity and portrays how the culmination of the two results in her disillusionment. Under an intersectional feminist lens, I examine Janie's romantic and sexual desire, desire to gain agency and finally her desire to achieve selfhood through asserting her identity and analyse how these ambitions are thwarted by marriage, family and restrictive attitudes to black female identity.

Throughout the novel, Janie's sexual and romantic desires are portrayed through organic metaphors of nature as she experiences the bodily and emotional changes throughout the transition of girlhood to womanhood. Hurston continually returns to the motif of a pear tree to depict Janie's sexual awakening and her maturing sensual and romantic desires. For example, Janie exclaims 'Oh to be a pear tree – *any* tree in bloom! With kissing bees singing of the beginning of the world!' (Hurston 25), which establishes her wish to freely explore becoming a woman through the illustrious possibilities of sexual desire. In particular, the verb 'bloom' (25) illustrates her excitement for her body to develop into its fully fledged womanly form, suggesting that Janie is excitedly anticipating coming into the prime of her life. This is reinforced by the asyndeton of Janie's body 'looking, waiting, breathing' (25) which quickens the pace of the sentence and exaggerates Janie's desperate impatience whilst 'waiting for the world to be made' (25) if she could actualise her sexual desires. Further, the holy song of the 'kissing bees' (25) ignites 'the beginning of the world' (25) for Janie, aligning sexuality with freedom which demonstrates how she perceives the start of her life as a woman to be able to exercise her sexual autonomy.

From a young age, Janie becomes disillusioned by her ability to achieve agency under the care of her grandmother who tells Janie's stories of her enslavement, marginalisation and her daughter's sexual abuse. Janie's grandmother functions as another 'character through which Hurston centers the embodied experience of intersectionality' (Dimitriou 409),

oppressed within slavery for the black and female intersections of her identity and concerned about Janie's inheritance of the same identities. These anxieties manifest and reach a climax once her grandmother sees 'Johnny Taylor lacerating Janie with a kiss' (Hurston 25-26) and realises that Janie is beginning to explore the freedom and excitement of sexual agency. The brutal verb 'lacerating' (26) presents this moment of sexual awakening as gravely dangerous for Janie because it is perceived through her grandmother who associates black female sexuality with violence, due to her both herself and her daughter having been sexually abuse by their enslavers. Consequently, her grandmother marries Janie off to Logan Killicks which 'emphasises the challenging social structure into which Janie is born [...] as predetermined, restricting, and subjugating from the position of an intersectional Black female subjectivity' (Dimitriou 408) by positioning Janie's blackness as vulnerable to sexual exploitation. The familial connection between Janie and her grandmother presents the intersectional oppression upon black women as a recurring generational issue within American society as her grandmother fear that Janie will become sexually exploited as she and her daughter were. This cements Janie's marriage to Logan as her first manifested experience of intersectional oppression, as her grandmother attempts to warn Janie of the subjugation that she will face for her black female identities, of which she does not yet comprehend within the naiveties of childhood.

Janie's grandmother overrides Janie's objections to Logan's appearance and pushes the marriage onto Janie so that she may be protected from the sexual threat of men in ways that she cannot provide. However, I argue that there is an element of parasitic feminism within this act because Janie's grandmother uses the patriarchal nature of marriage to her granddaughter's advantage because she knows that becoming a married woman will inherently gain Janie some power from a husband and his reputation. Her grandmother recognises that despite the abolition of slavery, 'the nigger woman is de mule uh de world' (Hurston 29), as racist notions about black women still pollute their society and oppress them. Although it deeply pains her to do so, her grandmother marries Janie off at a young age as a preventative measure in case the systematic oppression of black women does not alleviate and disappear within Janie's lifetime. In spite of Janie's disillusionment that her grandmother's actions are ones derived from cruelty, Hurston frames them as an attempt to take back agency through a white man from a society that harbors lingering societal

constructs designed to oppress her daughter. Janie's grandmother has forcibly encouraged Janie to take the financial and social security to allow her to fulfil her desires that she should be granted from wherever she can get it in life – starting with marriage.

I argue that within her marriages to Logan Killicks and Joe Starks, Janie becomes disillusioned by how the female intersection of her identity oppresses and diminishes the female desire for sex and sensuality within a heterosexual relationship. Hurston exhibits this through the connection between Janie and nature, which is consistently 'reflected throughout the story as she interprets her emotional world through contact with the physical world' (Knudsen 75), allowing Hurston to explicitly demonstrate when and how Janie's growing romantic and sexual desires become stunted and destroyed. Hurston does so by employing natural metaphors of regression and decay in contrast to natural metaphors of growth and bloom which 'associates control relationships with physical deformity, decay, and technological, non-sexual productivity' (Marks 152). This amplifies the starkness of Janie's disillusionment by the absence of space to explore her sexuality within marriage. For example, Hurston paints that Janie's 'vision of Logan Killicks was desecrating the pear tree' (Hurston 28), which evokes imagery of violent infection of the tree by killing it slowly while making it suffer. This vivid imagery illustrates the corrupting and violating effect that marrying Logan will have on Janie's romantic and sexual desires, polluted by his lack of respect for her and suffering in the absence of all intimacy and love.

Despite the fact that the prospect of marriage to Logan obliterates all prospects of Janie exploring her newfound sexual desires on her own terms, she follows through with it regardless, as her grandmother assures her it is the right thing to do. Tragically, Janie sacrifices her own desires to fulfil those of her grandmother, that she will gain financial security and protection from the institution of marriage. As nineteenth-century American laws constituted marriage as a patriarchal act in which 'a man and a woman became one person [...] and that person was legally him' (Nicholas 19) which renounced all independence and assets from the wife. Although Logan would also carry the legal duty that the 'husband was obligated to support his wife financially' (Nicholas 19), Janie would also have to surrender anything she obtained because 'anything a wife earned belonged to her husband' (19). Crucially, this disproportionately transactional agreement would extend to

sexuality and sexual encounters, as Logan ‘could not rape her because her marriage to him presumed ongoing sexual consent' (19), thus he may take whatever he wants from her regardless of Janie’s feelings. Thus, once Janie is married to Logan, she is further oppressed as she has no way of expressing her sexual desires unless she does so elsewhere with someone else, which would break the law. This drastically disillusions Janie as to the romantic sanctity of marriage, which she believes should principally celebrate and nurture her desires for sensuality and intimacy. However, she discovers that as a wife, achieving open sexuality and love requires her to forfeit her bodily autonomy for the sexual needs of her husband - a man that she is not even attracted to.

In her second marriage, Joe initially reciprocates Janie’s physical desire for him and the sexual promise he presents for her, but gradually their intimacy declines with Joe’s hyper fixation on village politics and his reputation within it. Hurston repats the use of natural metaphors of decomposition to reinforce that Janie’s romantic desires are dying with every new marriage and relationship she undergoes. Hurston eludes that after Joe’s neglect of her amorous desires she ‘has no more blossomy openings dusting pollen over her man, neither any glistening young fruit where the petals used to be’ (Hurston 112), as her marriages have not allowed her sexual desires to grow which results in the disillusionment that there is definitively no space for it to develop as a woman within heterosexual marriage. This cyclical imagery of blossom reverberates from the beginning of the novel and contrasts her sexual awakening and romantic prosperity with her disillusionment of not being able to explore them in marriage, which epitomises the regression of Janie’s sexuality. This is reinforced by the absence of ‘any glistening young fruit where the petals used to be’ (112), which implies that the pear tree is not growing correctly as it is failing to produce the fruit that the tree is meant to grow. This symbolises how Janie’s sexual and romantic desires are stunted and unable to grow within the environment and conditions of marriage where she must ‘press her teeth together and learn to hush’ (Hurston 111) and not express her desires. Eventually, Janie becomes not ‘petal-open anymore with him’ (Hurston 112) and her ‘bed becomes no longer a daisy field for her and Joe to play in’ (Hurston 111), which solidifies that their marriage has become devoid of all sexual intimacy and Janie has closed off of her sexuality and the possibility of intimacy altogether.

Hurston describes this crushing realisation of Janie's entrapment within marriage as a common fate for American women - 'Janie's first dream was dead, so became a woman' (Hurston 44). This depicts how severing dreams from reality and reducing expectations about the kind of life women wish to lead is imperative for women once they are married. Further, the adjective 'dead' (Hurston 44) emphasises how Janie becomes lifeless after realising that she must give up her desire for agency in her marriage and must allow herself to become depersonalised to endure her fate. This underpins how the disillusionment of accepting the impossibility for identity and agency in marriage is a prerequisite for surviving womanhood in 1930's America, especially for women like Janie who possess both black and female intersections of identity.

Despite this, I argue that Janie momentarily achieves her desire for agency when she spontaneously acts upon a 'feeling of sudden newness and change' (Hurston 54) and leaves this marriage. Although this assertion of authority over her own life being catalysed by the arrival of and political desires of another man, Joe Starks, Janie would have exited her old life 'even if Joe was not there waiting for her' (54). I argue that Janie perceives Joe's dreams of political power in Eatonville to align with her own desire for agency which ultimately fuels her decision to go with him and take advantage of where opportunity presents itself. In her new life in Eatonville, Janie obtains agency through her marriage to Joe who becomes the mayor, granting her the title of 'Mrs Mayor' (Hurston 74) within the community by establishing her rank and status above the other citizens. However, I argue that this honorific contraction emphasises how her power is derived from her marriage to a man and demonstrates how her only agency is an extension of Joe's, not her own.

In fact, Hurston centres Janie's desire to find and establish her identity as the main trajectory of her character and of the novel, sparked by the encouragement of her grandmother 'to know yo' ownself' (Hurston 21). Janie's grandmother acts as a matriarchal figure which Janie looks to for knowledge about the world and more specifically wisdom to find her place within it. Janie grows to realise why her grandmother encouraged her to assert her own identity and own her selfhood because she wanted Janie to never let 'de menfolks white or black make a spit cup outa you' (Hurston 37) to avoid being moulded by

men into what they desire to exploit her. Janie becomes rapidly disillusioned by the suffocating effect that marriage has upon her ability to maintain her sense of self and identity, as she is forced to assimilate foremost to the singular identity of wife to please both Logan and Joe. Throughout the novel, Hurston presents Janie's hair as the most consistent signifier of her identity, which echoes how in 'West and Central African societies from which most slaves in the Americas originated valued women's long, thick, styled hair [...] as a social and cultural signifier' (Ngandu 2) of the self. Hurston portrays Janie's rich cultural identity primarily through her physical features of 'a great rope of black hair' (Hurston 11) and mixed race which 'conform to the black version of the white ideal [...] : light skin and long hair' (Ashe 325-26), making her identity source for admiration and debate among the Eatonville community. The combination of the black and female intersections of her identity exhibited by her features construct Janie as paradoxically admired and alienated, as Eatonville 'attempts to place her because of her features (particularly her hair), on a social level [...] above and apart from the community' (Ashe 580) because her beautiful features do not conform to one singular cultural identity. This leaves Janie in a liminal space both detached from her black identity and praised for her white identity.

Furthermore, her desire to assert her identity is thwarted by Joe who attempts to control Janie's hair once he sees 'how often [...] other men figuratively wallow in it as she went about things in the store' (Hurston 87). Joe exercises the legal dominant power that marriage grants him and 'orders Janie to tie up her hair around the store' (Hurston 87) to conceal her hair to inhibit its attention and admiration by other men which oppresses the female intersection of Janie's identity. Additionally, the aggressive tonality of the imperative 'order' (87) exaggerates the authoritarian control he asserts over Janie 'to send a message to the men of the town, through Janie's hair, that Janie is for him and him alone, [...] that her hair is not hers to wear the way she wants' (Ashe 582), making Janie's hair function as a symbol of Joe's identity - not her own. Joe fears that Janie's hair and identity will be fetishised and eroticised by the other men in the village, so he tries to disguise the beauty of Janie's features as he is threatened by the attention they attract.

The conflict surrounding the presentation of Janie's hair is a microcosm of wider entrenched socio-political issues of how black women's 'hair has been weaponized to control, hypersexualize, and de-feminize Black women for centuries' (Ngandu 2) since slavery in the

Americas. During slavery ‘slave captors and traders routinely cut captives' hair off upon boarding the ship, and very few combs survived or were allowed on the transatlantic journey [...], as preliminary erasure of their African social and cultural identity, like the replacement of their African names with European ones’ (Ngandu 2). This emphasises the severity of the implications of Joe’s actions and the alienating impact they have upon Janie’s identity. This underpins how the black and female intersections of Janie’s female identity become lost and destablised within the socio-political climate of early twentieth century America, and within Joe’s desire to establish his identity within the Eatonville community which leaves her marginalised in the singular identity of wife.

Conclusion

This dissertation has reinforced that the lens of intersectionality is essential to understanding the tensions between desire and disillusionment for female characters in American fiction. Approaching the texts from an intersectional perspective has underpinned that ‘the tension between assertions of multiple identities and the ongoing necessity of group politics’ (Crenshaw 1296) for women constitutes the friction between desire and disillusionment for Jo, Ellen and Janie. I have shown that when they attempt to assert their unique identities by exploring their desires, the overwhelming cause of their disillusionment is the socio-economic, legalised and institutionalised structures of late-nineteenth and early twentieth-century America that oppress them for doing so. In particular, these texts portray the institution of marriage at the heart of complicating female desire because it demands the revoking of all individuality, financial freedom and sexuality to appease the patriarchy over themselves. I have demonstrated that Jo, Ellen and Jo all refuse to live for the pleasure of others and follow their own desires regardless of scandal and scrutiny, which I conclude is why their characters have previously been labelled notorious.

I have illuminated how Alcott, Wharton and Hurston embed sympathy within their novels towards their female protagonists as they endeavor to act upon their desires which I suggest is because they have all experienced the disadvantages of being female in

nineteenth-century America. Crucially, Hurston also endured hardships thrust on her by American society for the black intersection of her identity, which I perceive to be strongly infused into Janie's characterisation and her ability to achieve her desires. This is highly important to note because Hurston's personal experiences with intersectional oppression will likely have subconsciously contributed to a sharply authentic presentation of the internal conflicts between desire and disillusionment for Janie.

I have also shown how *Little Women*, *The Age of Innocence* and *Their Eyes Were Watching God* portray the effect that such limiting entrenched beliefs about the passive and docile nature of women have upon the desires of women. As we saw in Chapter One, Jo dims her great passion for writing to mold her writing into the stereotypically feminine and sentimental genre. Although she manages to fulfil her desire to become a writer, her most successful novel is the story of her own life which conforms to what was considered 'good writing for women [...] a product of the mind seeking solace for private pain [...] that seeks only to please [...] who constitute the immediate family' (Fetterley 374), writing in the memory of her beloved sister Beth. Jo's sentimental story is far removed from the theatrical and creative writing of her youth, but it has evolved, just like herself. Though critics may condemn Jo for ultimately submitting to the boundaries of patriarchal writing that she so detests; by publishing her own writing despite the feminine form, she can be seen to have achieved her desires. By the end of the novel, Jo has stepped 'into a paying job as a "scribbler" and [...] joins the working classes' (Foote 79-80) which transcends the overlapping oppression of her lower-class female identity by entering the public sphere.

Furthermore, in Chapter Two, we saw that Ellen defiantly possesses no desire to change how she wishes to live her life, however at the end of the novel she must leave American society altogether to do so. This yields to the patriarchal doctrine of gilded-age America that there is no place for a woman such as herself who does not follow the performative acts of her class nor the social laws of society. One may argue that Ellen is defeated by her inability to achieve her desires of divorce and freedom from scandal in American class-culture when she flees the country to Europe. However, I perceive that Ellen ultimately succeeds in satisfying her desires to be free of observation, and of her husband by actively moving her life to a place where she may do so. Ellen has witnessed post-civil war New York society for what it is disillusioned by its vicious cruelty and rigid hierarchies thus rebelliously chooses to

leave it behind for the pursuit of her own happiness. In doing so, Ellen 'defies society's rules [...] in refusing to play Old New York's game – she shows that she can rise above the game' (Ingley 604), above depending on a man for her fulfilment and above the scrutiny of maintaining reputation.

Finally, in Chapter Three, we saw that Janie's desires were initially shaped by the hands of her grandmother who forced Janie to become hyperaware of her intersectional identity from a young age and the impact that it will likely have upon her life – as it did for grandmother. Hurston exposes how young black women like Janie become disillusioned by the restricted possibilities for their futures as soon as they become aware of the impact that intersectional identity has upon their agency, freedom and general passion for life. Janie makes her desires for selfhood and sexuality smaller to fit within the realms of opportunity she was offered as a child within the embedded patriarchal oppression of marriage to pursue them. Despite her empowered decision to leave her first marriage she only acts upon the arrival of a new man in her life – Joe Starks. Although Janie actively alters the course of her life to retrieve her agency, it is difficult to ignore that she must find it within the power of the male intersection of Joe's identity.

In fact, as the novel progresses 'Janie's settings and circumstances appear to recede into the antebellum past, highlighting the challenges that must be overcome in light of an exclusionary women's suffrage movement and a failed Reconstruction' (Dimitriou 408), as she goes from marriage to marriage repeatedly mistreated in all of them. This is underpinned in my wider research that has shown that Jo and Ellen are able to overcome their intersectional identities even if it is to a confined extent, which I suggest is because they do not possess the intersection of black identity. Furthermore, even after Janie meets Teacake towards the end of the novel, someone who respects her and whom she can express her long-repressed sexual and romantic desires, he physically abuses her. Janie faces domestic abuse by all the men in her life when they feel threatened by her succeeding attempts to actualise her desires and assert her selfhood. The oppressive effects of physical violence that Janie faces throughout her life across all her marriages is reinforced as inescapable by the notable cyclical structure of the novel. Janie returns to her hometown where the novel began, which places Janie back in the physical and emotional space of her childhood which allows Hurston to portray Janie's disillusioned reflection upon the various

austerities and adversities she has faced for the black intersection of her identity along the path for her desires - as her grandmother predicted. Although Hurston illustrates that Janie believes that the moments of intersectional oppression that she experienced throughout her life made her into who she is, this leaves an ambiguously uplifting tone to the end of the novel. Janie accepts that her experience of the tensions between desire and disillusionment caused by systematic intersectional oppression were in fact necessary to ultimately achieve her desires for selfhood, sexuality and agency.

Overall, my research has exhibited how Jo, Ellen and Janie ultimately alter their desires to be within the realms of nineteenth and twentieth-century patriarchal America to move them into the realms of possibility. I have done so to invite criticism of the different versions of American society that they exist within, rather than their survival responses to those conditions and how they impact their lives. It is also vital to consider how the structure of these novels illuminate how patriarchal norms impact the desires of young developing young women who are impressionable to these unrealistic expectations. In both *Little Women* and *Their Eyes Were Watching God*, the novels begin with the female protagonists as girls and end with them as women, which forces the reader to focus on the female intersections of their identity and exaggerates the length of time it takes for them to overcome the burdens placed upon them by their sex that inhibit the trajectory of their ambitions. Whereas, in *The Age of Innocence*, Wharton uses structure differently as Ellen is already a woman who remains the same age throughout the entire novel which accentuates the short period that the novel spans. This spotlights Ellen's feelings of stagnation within a society that slows her from the projectile of her life and her dreams, despite her being a grown woman who can ostensibly make her own choices. It also allows Wharton to criticise that Ellen only needs to be in New York for a short amount of time to become disillusioned by it so much that she leaves it. In conclusion, these three novels present how women become disillusioned by their ability to achieve their desires and their lives' prospects within different versions of patriarchal American societies before they have even begun.

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